

Moloch horridus

Thorny devil



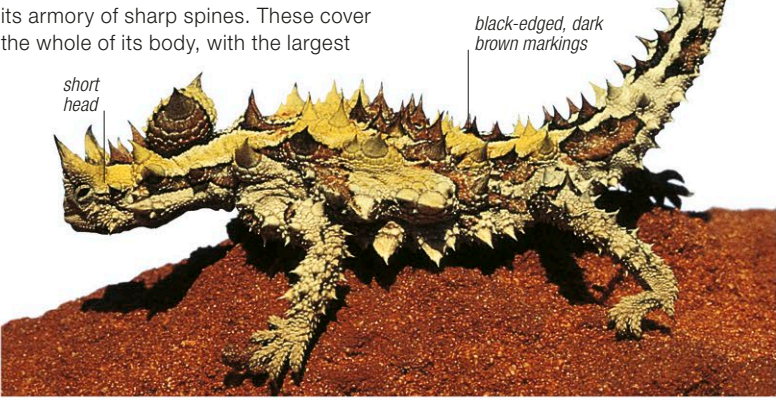
Length 6–7 in (15–18 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location W. to C. Australia



Although it is not often seen—partly because it is well camouflaged—the buff, tan, or gray thorny devil is instantly recognizable by its squat shape, its slow way of moving, rocking backward and forward as it walks, and its army of sharp spines. These cover the whole of its body, with the largest

spines on its head and back, and much smaller ones on its legs and feet. Such protection is vital for the thorny devil because, unlike most lizards, it spends a lot of time foraging in one place on the ground, leaving it vulnerable to attack while feeding. Like the desert horned lizard (see p.416), which shares a similar way of life, the thorny devil feeds during the day, when ants are on the move, and can consume up to 2,500 insects during a single meal, catching them with its projecting tongue. Females lay 3–10 eggs in underground burrows in summer.



Physignathus cocincinus

Asian water dragon



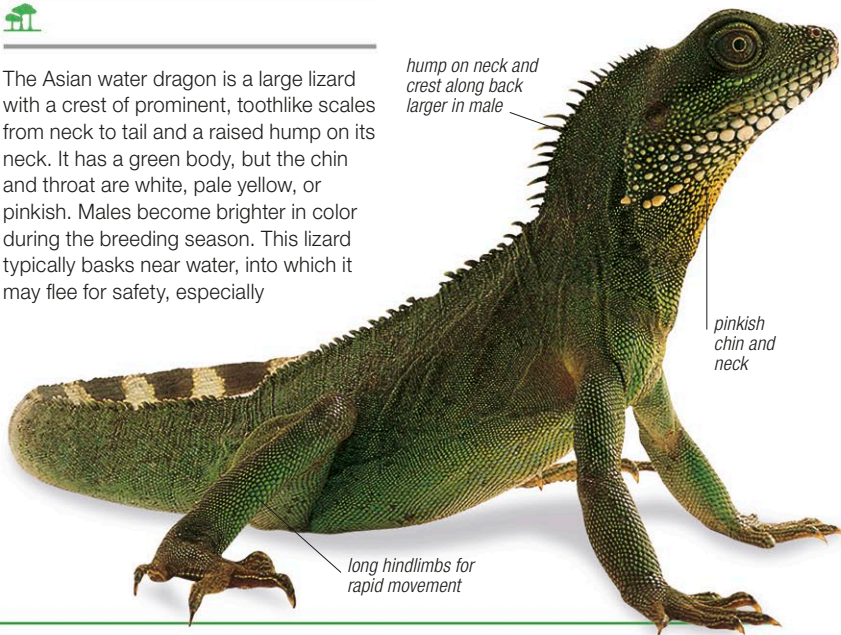
Length 2½–3¼ ft (80–100 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S.E. Asia (Thailand, Cambodia, and Vietnam)



The Asian water dragon is a large lizard with a crest of prominent, toothlike scales from neck to tail and a raised hump on its neck. It has a green body, but the chin and throat are white, pale yellow, or pinkish. Males become brighter in color during the breeding season. This lizard typically basks near water, into which it may flee for safety, especially

when hunted by snakes and birds of prey. It hunts primarily by ambushing its prey, which comprises invertebrates and small vertebrates such as lizards; however, it also forages actively for food, and may occasionally graze upon vegetation. Females lay multiple clutches of 10–15 eggs throughout an extended breeding season, in burrows or shallow scrapes, and cover the eggs with soil and leaves.



Pogona vitticeps

Central bearded dragon



Length 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semi-arboreal
Status Not evaluated

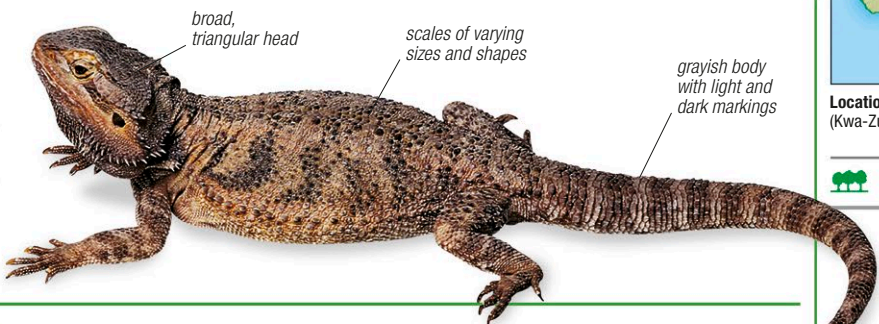
Location Australia



This bulky lizard inhabits dry forest, woodland, and scrubland, resting on stumps or raised humps on the ground,

and foraging for small insects and vegetation near its regular perch. If confronted by a predator—usually birds of prey, monitor lizards, or snakes—it erects its black throat frill, or “beard,” and presents a wide, open mouth. The males, and even the females,

are territorial. The female lays several clutches of 15–30, and occasionally more, eggs throughout the breeding season, burying them in sandy soil. The hatchlings’ body markings are more distinctive than those of adults, but they do not possess a beard.



Bradypodion thamnobates

Natal Midlands dwarf chameleon



Length 6–7½ in (15–19 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Near threatened

Location Southern Africa (Kwa-Zulu Natal)



Dwarf chameleons are largely restricted to southern Africa, where they live in forest and scrub. They differ from most other chameleons in giving birth to live young. The Natal Midlands dwarf chameleon is a typical species, with a high protuberance, or casque, covering its neck. Its coloration is highly variable, but the long-tailed males, which are often green, are more colorful than the females and juveniles, which are brown or gray. Like other chameleons, it is specially adapted for life in trees, and feeds on insects, which it captures with its long, sticky tongue.

Uromastix acanthinura

North African mastigure



Length 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

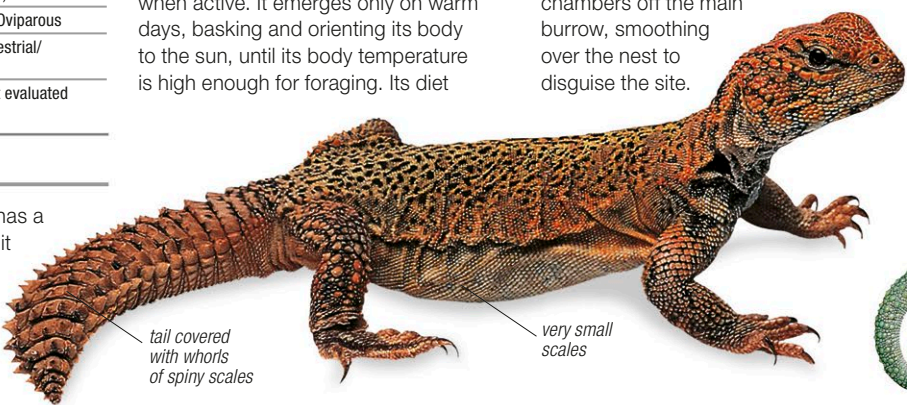
Location N. Africa



The North African mastigure has a short, thick, armored tail that it uses to block the entrance to its burrow to deter predatory birds or mammals. Inside the burrow, it inflates its body to wedge itself in.

It may also use its tail as a club and may bite if cornered. Males, and occasionally females, are aggressively territorial. The coloration of this lizard varies according to temperature: gray or yellowish brown in cold weather, when it hibernates, changing to orange, red, yellow, or green when active. It emerges only on warm days, basking and orienting its body to the sun, until its body temperature is high enough for foraging. Its diet

consists of insects and plants, and it may walk over 2½ mile (1 km), zigzagging across rocky outcrops in the desert, to find favored plant species. Females lay at least 2 clutches of 20–30 eggs a year, then bury them in side chambers off the main burrow, smoothing over the nest to disguise the site.



conical scales form crest on back

